tasks involved flushing out the terrorists from their hideouts in certain gurudwaras, their arrest and the seizure of their weapons. Her expectation was that the very presence of the army and the demonstration of its strength through flag marches would, by themselves, act as deterrents. Consequently, she felt that there would not be any need for use of excess force by the army.' [3]

Simultaneously, she also called moderate Akali Dal leaders to Delhi for secret talks on 26 May with some of her cabinet colleagues. Expectedly, these talks also met with their predetermined fate (see Chapter 4). After the failed 26 May talks with Akali leaders, a meeting was held at the cabinet secretariat on the morning of 27 May, which was attended by Cabinet Secretary Krishnaswamy Rao Sahib, Senior Advisor R.N. Kao, Principal Secretary to the PM P.C. Alexander and General Vaidya. General Vaidya's 25 May plan was discussed in detail and he was given the go-ahead to implement it.

However, on General Vaidya's request, an urgent meeting was held at the prime minister's South Block office on 29 May, where both R.N. Kao and P.C. Alexander were present. Vaidya mentioned that he had discussed the 25 May plan with Lt Gen. K. Sundarji, GOC-in-C, western command, who was of the view that the plan could work only for smaller gurudwaras and not for the Golden Temple, as a prolonged siege of the Golden Temple could lead to a mass upsurge of Sikhs around the state, who could then march towards the Golden Temple.

Surprised at this sudden change in the plan, Indira Gandhi enquired about the implications of a stiff resistance by the terrorists holed up in the complex and their taking refuge in the inner sanctum of Harmandir Sahib. She also asked for a comparative analysis of the original plan with the alternative in terms of the number of casualties and the impact of the operations on serving Sikh jawans (soldiers) in the Indian army.

Fully supportive of Lt Gen. Sundarji's suggestion for revising the original plan, General Vaidya said no time should be lost and the army needed to make a quick entry into the Golden Temple and take the terrorists by surprise. According to him, the operation would be carried out with 'such swiftness and surprise that it would not result